

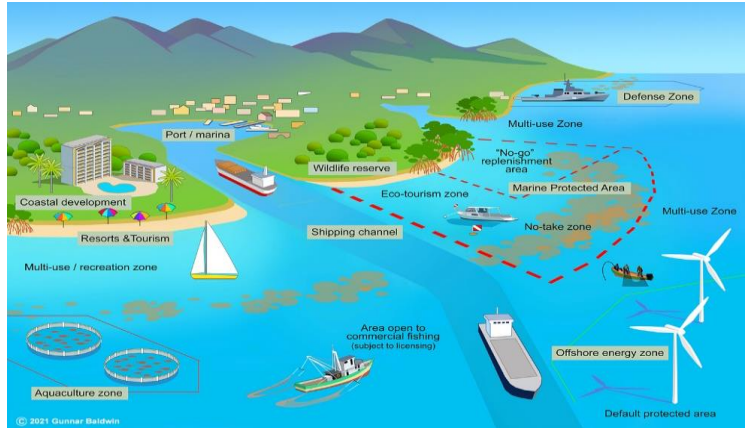
PLANNING THE OCEAN TOGETHER

20TH April, 2026

Integrating Indigenous and Local Community Women's Knowledge in Marine Spatial Planning

What is Marine Spatial Planning (MSP)?

MSP is a practical way of organizing how ocean space is used. It helps governments, communities, and ocean users decide where activities such as fishing, tourism, shipping, conservation, and energy development should take place, and how to protect important ecosystems. Essentially, MSP helps to reduce conflicts, protect biodiversity, plan for climate impacts, and ensure resources are available for future generations.



Marine Spatial Planning. Source: Tuckerman reef. <https://www.tuckermanreef.com/msp-and-iczm.html>

Inclusive Participation in MSP Processes

Women in indigenous and local coastal communities play vital roles in coastal life and are the primary custodians ensuring the intergenerational transmission of traditional marine knowledge, language, and cultural practices. They hold generations of knowledge about tides, species behavior, seasonal changes, and ecosystem health, yet they are often underrepresented in marine planning due to gender-blind processes or restrictive cultural codes.



Opportunities for Integrating Indigenous and Local Community Knowledge into MSP

At WASMaN, we believe that by enhancing the full participation of indigenous and local coastal women in MSP processes, planning becomes more inclusive, draws on a wider range of knowledge and experiences, and leads to more sustainable and equitable management of marine resources. The following actions can be taken to enhance the integration process:

- Leading community dialogues and consultations where women's voices are often underrepresented
- Conducting participatory research with fishing communities, processors, gleaners, and traders
- Documenting local ecological knowledge, including species changes, spawning periods, and harvesting practices
- Acting as translators, facilitators, and knowledge brokers between scientists, policymakers, and communities
- Training local women's and youth groups to participate in ocean stewardship